

Microsoft releases Application Inspector as open source software

According to a report by ZDNet, the Microsoft Application Inspector, an open source command-line tool, has been released. It is used by the company's engineers to probe third party open source software components for security issues.



The report said that the static source code analyser aims to help developers handle potential security issues, which come up through code reuse while incorporating open source components like software libraries into a project.

Guy Acosta and Michael Scovetta, members of Microsoft's customer security and trust team, wrote that reuse has great benefits which include faster time to market, better quality, and interoperability. But it also comes with the cost of hidden complexity and risks.

They further commented that the user trusts the engineering team but the code they write accounts for only a tiny fraction of the entire application. Acosta and Scovetta noted that modern Web applications often have hundreds of third party components. They contain tens of thousands of lines of code, which are written by thousands of contributors. Most of the time, developers who use those components rely on the author's description, which may not be reliable or enough to meet Microsoft's responsibility for shipping secure code which includes external components.

According to Microsoft, the Application Inspector is a unique static code analyser because it does not flag 'good' or 'bad' patterns. It highlights 'interesting' features based on over 500 rule patterns. The tool can help identify these interesting characteristics more quickly than manual introspection. Application Inspector is built on .NET Core. It can be used by developers on Windows, Linux or macOS.

Application Inspector produces a browser based report that summaries the major characteristics identified. It includes application frameworks, cloud interfaces, cryptography, sensitive data like access keys, personally identifiable information, operating system functions, and security features.

Facebook open sources Polygames

Facebook has made Polygames open source. Polygames is an AI research framework for training agents to learn strategy games through self-play and not by studying examples of successful gameplay.

A report by Analytics India Magazine stated that Polygames can help researchers to advance and benchmark a wide range of zero learning (ZL) techniques that do not require training data sets. The architecture of Polygames makes it compatible with games like Breakthrough, Hex, Havannah, Minishogi, Connect6, Minesweeper, Mastermind, EinStein würfelt nicht!, Nogo, and Othello. According to the report, Polygames will allow researchers to study transfer learning. It also provides a library of included games and single-file APIs to implement one's own game.



Facebook AI Research

The Facebook AI team has demonstrated the effectiveness of Polygames as a training tool with good performances in various game competitions. This included making the first bot to beat a top human player in the game 19x19 Hex.